

Linear Programming Course Summary

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1 Key Terms

- **Slack Variable:** A variable added to a less-than-or-equal-to inequality constraint to transform it into an equality constraint. It represents the difference between the left-hand side and right-hand side of the inequality.
- **Feasible Region:** The set of all points that satisfy all the constraints of a linear programming problem.
- **Vertex:** A point where two or more constraint boundaries intersect in the feasible region of a linear programming problem. In the Simplex method, optimal solutions are found at vertices.
- **Basic Variable:** In the Simplex method, a variable that is expressed in terms of non-basic variables in a dictionary. In a basic feasible solution, basic variables are non-negative.
- **Non-basic Variable:** In the Simplex method, a variable set to zero in a given iteration of the algorithm. The values of the basic variables are determined by the values of the non-basic variables.
- **Pivot Operation:** The process of exchanging a basic and a non-basic variable in the Simplex method, leading to a new basic feasible solution.
- **Dictionary:** A representation of a linear programming problem where basic variables are expressed as functions of non-basic variables. It is used in the Simplex method to systematically move from one vertex to another.
- **Auxiliary Problem:** A modified linear programming problem introduced to find an initial feasible solution when the origin is not feasible in the original problem. It involves adding a new variable to shift the feasible region.

2 Problem Types

- **Finding an Initial Feasible Solution:** The Simplex method requires an initial feasible solution. If the origin is not feasible, an auxiliary problem is introduced to find a feasible solution to the original problem.
- **Handling Infeasible Origins:** The origin $(0,0)$ may not satisfy all constraints in a linear programming problem. Techniques like introducing an auxiliary problem are used to find a feasible starting point.
- **Optimizing in Higher Dimensions:** The Simplex method is extended to linear programming problems with more than two variables, requiring iterative pivoting operations to find the optimal solution.
- **Using Dictionaries to Represent Solutions:** The Simplex method uses dictionaries to represent the current solution and to perform pivot operations efficiently. Each dictionary corresponds to a vertex of the feasible region.

3 Algorithm Solutions

- **Simplex Method:** Iteratively move from one vertex of the feasible region to another by setting non-basic variables to zero and choosing a new set of (non)basic variables to improve the objective function value. This is equivalent to moving from vertex to vertex in the feasible region.
- **Auxiliary Problem:** When the origin is not feasible, introduce a new variable x_0 and modify the constraints to create an auxiliary problem that maximizes $-x_0$. Solve this auxiliary problem to find a feasible solution for the original problem. If the optimal solution has $x_0 = 0$, then a feasible solution to the original problem is found.